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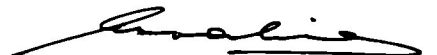
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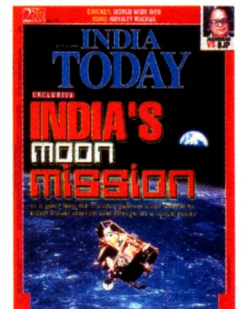
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I have an indelible image of one of the rockets of India's first space flight being carried to its launch site on a bullock cart in the '60s. Maybe that's what made me a space cynic and cost me a bottle of champagne. I took a bet with our Managing Editor Raj Chengappa, our resident space expert, that India would not get to the moon. Well, he's over the moon and I owe him a bottle of champagne. It's one bet I'm happy to lose. Government-run institutions in the country are not known for consistently high standards of achievement and innovation but the Indian Space Research Organisation, or ISRO, is an outstanding exception. The launch of Chandrayaan-1 on a mission to map the moon's surface allows India to join a select space club and is a huge milestone in the country's space programme.

Moon missions, I honestly felt, were passé. America landed a man on the moon in 1969 and their last moon shot was in 1972 (they sent up an orbiter in 1994) while the former Soviet Union ended their Luna probes in 1976. The 67 moon missions so far have brought back 400 kg of moon rock, enough for scientific research. So why is India making such a big deal about its lunar probe? It puts us with the big boys of space. A scientific super-power. This is, to paraphrase the first man on the moon, a giant leap for ISRO. In the three decades of its existence, ISRO has never attempted anything as ambitious. The moon, 3,84,467 km from the earth, is 10 times farther than any ISRO rocket has reached and the journey involves a series of highly complex and sophisticated assignments. That alone propels India's space programme to a new level. When ISRO's probe orbits the moon on November 15, India will join America, Russia, Europe, Japan and China to have sent lunar missions. Also, China has just sent a man into space and the Asian space race between the two to put a man on the moon could rival the riveting one between the Americans and the former Soviet Union four decades ago.

There are larger ambitions into planetary explorations and even manned space flights. There is renewed global interest after recent probes discovered water on the lunar surface which opens the possibility of establishing a station on the moon and as a base for further probes to Mars. Recently, celebrated physicist Stephen Hawkins stated that if the human race is to continue for another million years, we will need to set up colonies on Mars and the moon. India could find itself helping the world reach a new frontier. There are also numerous strategic and technological spin-offs, apart from the prospect of finding and transporting Helium-3, a possible answer to the world's energy needs. However, I'm keeping that champagne on ice till November 15, when we can celebrate India's great technological achievement.


(Aroon Purie)



Our July 2000 cover